hated losing and as captain of the team I felt responsible for the string of miserable performances. More worryingly, I did not know how I could turn it around, as I was already trying my absolute best.

Not long after the series was over, I confided in Anjali that I feared there was nothing more that I could do to stem the tide of defeats. Losing a string of very close matches had left me badly scarred. I had given it everything and was not sure that I could give even 0.1 per cent more. The fact that we failed to chase down 120 had nothing to do with lack of talent. It was because we batted horribly on the day. It was hurting me badly and it took me a long time to come to terms with these failures. I even contemplated moving away from the sport completely, as it seemed nothing was going my way. Anjali, as usual, managed to put things in perspective and assured me that things would surely get better in the months to come. Looking back, it was just frustration getting the better of me.

The final few months

The string of defeats came to a temporary halt when we drew a two-Test series in Sri Lanka in August 1997 and then beat Pakistan 4–1 in the Sahara Cup, a one-day series in Toronto, in September. The tournament was memorable because Sahara had not only lent their name as sponsors but senior officials like Abhijit Sarkar were personally there to ensure that everything was in order and players felt comfortable. This win was all the more satisfying because we played without Srinath, Prasad and Anil Kumble, and we had a young bowling unit. Sourav Ganguly was the star performer for us in the series, winning four Man of the Match awards on the trot.

There was one rather strange incident during the second match of this series involving Inzamam-ul-Haq. While it appears funny in hindsight, it wasn’t at the time. During one of the drinks breaks when we were batting, having bowled Pakistan out for 116, one of the Pakistan players who wasn’t playing in the match took out a bat for Inzamam – to the great surprise of those of us watching from the dressing room. We initially thought he was taking the bat out to get it autographed; only later did we realize that Inzamam wanted it in order to charge at a few fans in the crowd who were taunting him because of his physique!